The Story of Indian Philosophy

Indian philosophy is perhaps the earliest recorded thought of man. Its four thousand years of history embracing the multitudinous phases of intense enquiry cannot possibly be done justice in this chapter. Only a bird's-eye view of this vast panorama is possible in the following survey.

THE VEDAS

The *Vedas* (2500-2000 B. C.), which embody divine truths, are believed to have been revealed to the super-consciousness of the seers. They represent the fountainhead of Hindu philosophical thought. Each of the four *Vedas, Rig-Veda, Yajur-Veda, Sāma-Veda* and *Atharva-Veda,* has three main divisions: the *Samhitās* (sacred texts), the *Brāhmaṇas* (commentaries) and the *Āraṇyakas* (forest books). The *Rig-Veda Samhitā* is the oldest record of Hindu philosophical thought.

To begin with, man looks outside. His first thoughts therefore relate to the sequence of natural phenomena in which he sees the causes of vicissitudes of his everyday life. The early *mantras* (hymns), thus, contain an element of nature worship, in which the various powers of nature such as fire (Agni) and wind (Vāyu), which influence human life, are personified as gods, whom it is a man's duty to propitiate. Varuṇa and Indra are the chief among them, the former being conceived as a symbol of omniscience and righteousness. The gods being righteous are believed to uphold *Rta,* or the physical and moral order in the universe. The relationship of man to gods who are conceived as originating and sustaining the world is one of utter dependence. Man, it is maintained, must lead a righteous life to please the gods who are good. In Vedic religious thought the unreality of the universe is never suggested. In fact, worldly prosperity and the joys of everyday life are con-